SEATO and CENTO. It also hosted an American base in Peshawar and was deeply involved in Western intelligence operations. This alliance became in due course a story of high stakes and daring policy options. But the shift in 1963 has fundamentally shaped Chinese thinking since then. Cooperation intensified and even gave Pakistan some misplaced hopes of Chinese support during the 1965 and 1971 conflicts with India.

The contemporary phase of their ties saw many of these very issues evolve further. There has been a longstanding debate in India on how it is perceived by China. Pakistan provides an answer to that calculation. But this concern was dampened at the end of the 1980s, when India and China were focusing on repairing the breaches of the past. It had taken fourteen years after the 1962 war for ambassadorial relations to be restored in 1976. Now it took twelve more for a Prime Minister of India, Rajiv Gandhi, to travel to China in 1988. The focus was on normalizing ties and stabilizing the border, objectives largely achieved over the next decade. The peace and tranquillity agreements signed in 1993 and 1996 represented the logical follow-through of these goals.

For both nations, the events leading up to 1988 were a long-awaited correction. India had improved its ties with the US through the 1980s and was concerned at the adverse fallout of the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan. The revival of Pakistan’s alliance with the US was deeply detrimental to its interests. Though closely involved in the Afghan jihad, China was noting as it unfolded a weakening USSR with an amenable leadership. Improved bilateral ties were in the interest of both India and China at this juncture, as neither saw the other as a dominant concern. Economically, the two societies were broadly on par, though China had some inherent strengths that were still to kick in. Politically, of course, China had a clear edge, partly because of the 1962 outcome, but also as its alliance with the West was now really paying off. Still, it was a meeting of considerable promise for a frozen and troubled relationship. Subsequent events were to reveal that it was also one of significant misreading by India.

The events of the early 1960s had brought out the geopolitical nature of the relationship that was accentuated by ideological differences. China has already displayed stark realpolitik in its handling of India by swiftly